

THE UNIVERSAL HOUSE OF JUSTICE

27 September 2007

To National Spiritual Assemblies

Dear Bahá'í Friends,

Over the years, the Universal House of Justice has encouraged National Spiritual Assemblies throughout the world to make suitable provisions for the care of the properties of the Faith in the countries and territories under their jurisdiction. Some National Assemblies have been able to establish comprehensive programmes for the maintenance of these properties, while the degree to which other National Assemblies have been able to systematize this area of their responsibility varies widely. The House of Justice has, therefore, asked us to write to National Assemblies to recommend that they put in place, if they have not already done so, proper systems and procedures to safeguard these assets of the Faith and to remind them of some points they should bear in mind when addressing these matters.

As a first step, each National Assembly should have on hand, or compile if necessary, a current list of the properties within its national jurisdiction which includes basic facts about each one, such as a short description, utilization, legal status, current value, maintenance costs, and so on. Ideally, this list would be supplemented, wherever possible, by photographs of the sites and buildings. Once compiled, this list should be reviewed regularly and updated as circumstances dictate. It is, of course, of paramount importance that the National Assembly make certain it has clear legal ownership of each property to the extent possible, that the title deeds and other documents proving ownership are in safe custody, and that copies are sent to the Bahá'í World Centre for further safe keeping.

It is likewise essential that the properties are regularly inspected and cared for, that repairs are carried out promptly, and that payments of land taxes or rates are made in a timely fashion. Furthermore, the National Assembly should safeguard its rightful possession of a property against such dangers as encroachment by neighbours, unauthorized occupancy by squatters, or issues of possible government expropriation of the land, any of which could result in long and expensive legal proceedings to rectify.

It is the hope of the House of Justice that, by following these steps, every National Assembly will ensure that the properties for which it has responsibility will be a source of pride and prestige to the entire community.

With loving Bahá'í greetings,

Department of the Secretariat

[signed: The Universal House of Justice]